

Trapped and Suffering: How America’s Prison System Causes Physical and Mental Suffering

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Introduction/Background

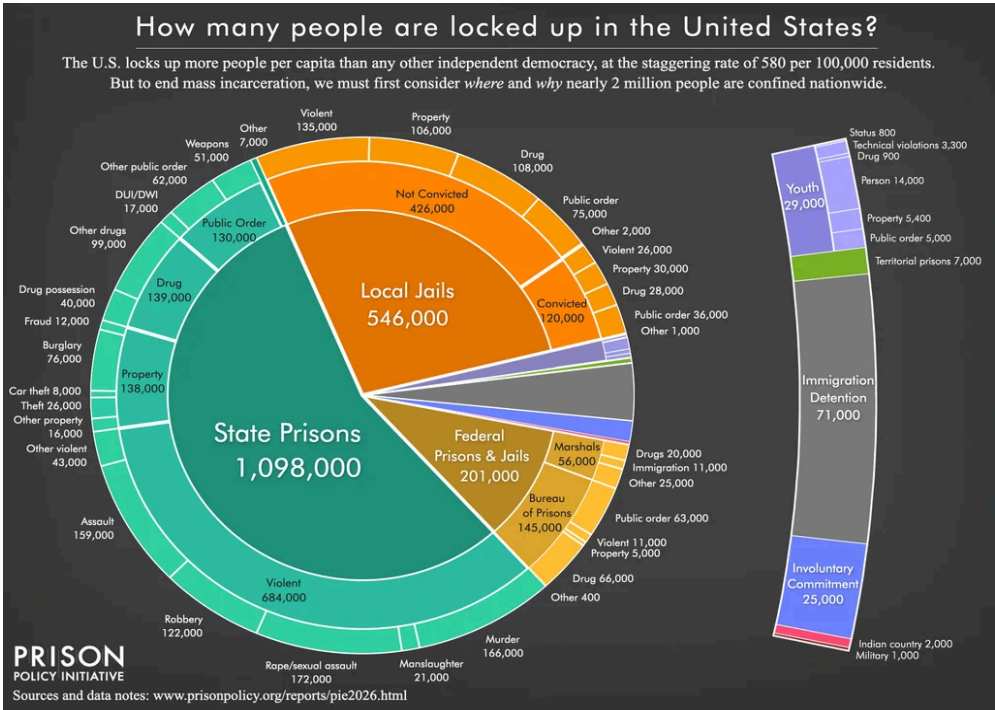
America is known to have one of the greatest legal systems in the world. Some qualities of this justice system include its strict enforcement, affordability, and multiple chances, making it “orderly and fair.” Despite these secure qualities, how it performs is essentially flawed because of what incarcerated people deal with inside the prison system.

Overcrowding and Neglect

With over 2 million people in the US prison system at any given time, there have been many instances where prisoners are often crammed into small, claustrophobic cells, faced harsh heat and cold without proper ventilation and climate control, deal with unsanitary and disgusting food and sanitary conditions, and are deprived of access to educational, social, and legal services (Sawyer et al., 2026; Western, 2021). The conditions of overcrowding and ineffective services and facilities can lead to prisoners' loss of humanity and dignity, which can lead to an increase in mental illness, violence, assaults, and suicide (Western, 2021; Hopwood, 2021).

Figure 1

Current US Prison Population and Distributions



(Sawyer et al., 2026)

*As one of the largest prison systems in the world that has **billions** invested, most inmates are often worse off than those who are **homeless** or **living in poverty**.*

Overcrowding in prisons has been a persistent issue for almost 20 years now, and continues to be a problem in prisons even today. As of 2019, Iowa leads the nation in prison overcrowding, with its prison population at 119% of its operational capacity (the number of prisoners a prison can accommodate) (Spohn & Kiper, 2025). Over 10 states have reached or exceeded their operational capacity, with prison capacity exceeding design capacity, leaving insufficient physical space to house all prisoners (Spohn & Kiper, 2025). With such overcrowding and crowded spaces, this increases tension and stress in the prison community, leading to violent actions and deterioration (Spohn & Kiper, 2025; Western, 2021). One important example was in 2009, when most California prisons were overcrowded at 150% of the designed capacity; most prisoners were at disarray, with hundreds of cases of violence, extreme health risks, and as the current governor at the time, Arnold Schwarzenegger reported “... that the suicide rate in the 29 severely overcrowded prisons “[was] approaching an average of one per week (Western, 2021).” It seems that the problem of overcrowding has not been solved, remaining the same as it was in the 80s and '90s.

Table 1

The Top 10 States for Overcrowded Prisons

State	Prison Population	Rated Capacity	Operational Capacity	Design Capacity
Iowa	8,438	119.00%	119.00%	119.00%
Nebraska	5,546	No Data Provided	115.40%	156.90%
Idaho	8,422	No Data Provided	110.10%	No Data Provided
Colorado	15,689	No Data Provided	106.80%	119.40%
Georgia	54,620	91.60%	105.40%	No Data Provided
Washington	17,882	No Data Provided	105.30%	No Data Provided
Montana	1,985	98.70%	102.60%	173.80%
Wisconsin	23,402	No Data Provided	101.00%	137.80%
Hawaii	3,550	101.80%	100.70%	100.70%

With most prisons operating beyond their capacity, this has led to more issues with facilities and services provided to prisoners. Prisoners are often guaranteed certain privileges, such as their own beds, bathrooms, food, and educational, social, and legal services (Western, 2021). This is to ensure the prisoners can be reintegrated and rehabilitated into normal society after their release. However, with prisons at almost full or exceeding capacity, these services often break down and fail, leading to issues of unsanitary conditions, neglect, and non-compliance with prisoners.

One such issue is heat, which is more evident in southern states such as Alabama, Texas, and Georgia. Often, prison climate systems fail without warning, resulting in extremely sweltering conditions reaching 103-110°F for weeks on end (Kaufman et al., 2025). With understaffed facilities, poor conditions of prisons, and even legal and political issues, systems at these prisons do not get repaired, leading to increased violence, heat stroke, dehydration, and even deaths, which accounted for almost 13% of all deaths in Texas prisons during the summer months (Kaufman et al., 2025; Hopwood, 2021).

If heat and climate are not the issue, then lavatories, food, and prisoners' services are other points of failure. Often, correctional facilities have very unsanitary conditions in lavatories and food preparation areas, creating a risk of bacterial contamination and illness (Western, 2021; CT Office of Correction Ombuds, 2026). According to a report from the Connecticut Office of the Correction Ombuds, there is extensive damage to showers and bathrooms in most state prisons, and a lack of basic cleaning and hygiene supplies (2026). Additionally, there is a worrying amount of structural and facility damage, with mold, rust, and corrosion present at most facilities, raising concerns about injury and illness from mold, fiberglass, and rust (CT Office of Correction Ombuds, 2026).

Figure 2

Bathroom ceiling exhibiting mold growth and condensation at Hartford Correctional Center



(CT Office of Correction Ombuds, 2026)

Besides physical conditions, social, legal, and educational services are often nonexistent or in poor condition in prisons. Reports show that many services, such as libraries and phones, are often restricted or inoperable, with officials stating repairs or budget cuts (CT Office of Correction Ombuds, 2026). Without these services, people are unable to communicate with family and friends, furthering distress and isolation among prisoners. State legal assistance organizations that help poor/disadvantaged prisoners with legal work, parole, and other services are also very important to prisoners. Still, as before, these services are often understaffed and underfunded, leading many prisoners to report being turned away or neglected when seeking legal help (CT Office of Correction Ombuds, 2026).

“I wrote like 20 lawyers [regarding a medical grievance] but I never got a response back I even wrote ILAP they basically told me that I'm not going to get much out of the situation so I just left it alone cause I could not find any help (CT Office of Correction Ombuds, 2026).”

With unsuitable, dangerous conditions in prisons, combined with mass incarceration and now immigration detentions, prisons are turning from a place of rehabilitation and redemption to more of a breeding ground for sickness, violence, and death. Moreover, it seems these situations are unlikely to improve or be addressed by politicians and

policymakers, as funding has been allocated to many services and facilities at both the federal and state levels. The Department of Justice has already cut about \$819.7 million in grants for federal rehabilitation and education resources, and in Florida, the governor has cut at least \$840 million from the correctional budget for construction and repairs (Solomon & Betsy Pear, 2025; Joseph-Marc, 2025). Without any sort of reforms or policies to repair, oversee, and accommodate the growing prisoner population, the consequences will surely increase.

Healthcare

Healthcare is designed to improve the “health and well-being of individuals and communities, including preventive, diagnostic, therapeutic, rehabilitative, maintenance, monitoring, and counseling services. ()” However, this is not the case for incarcerated individuals who lie in prison facilities. Many prisoners requiring medical attention were often ignored and left to die after being glanced at by the time it's too late. The staff’s ignorance or lack of care for the prisoners’ health leads to unnecessary suffering and can be seen as more inhumane than the death penalty itself. In order for prisons to become adequate at improving the health of prisoners are doctor-patient relationships, careful and more intensive attention towards prisoners, better regulations to ensure prisoners’ comfort, and the needs of those with conditions.

Doctor-patient relationships are a key factor in one’s good health. Illinois courts define this relationship as “a consensual relationship in which the patient knowingly seeks the physician’s assistance and in which the physician knowingly accepts the person as a patient. ()” In order to have this relationship, there needs to be total truth told from both parties, but this would be extremely difficult to establish if the medical personnel clearly don’t give attention to inmates. One person that suffered from the lack of attention from doctors was Jason Phillips, a prisoner who would’ve served six more years after his death. He passed away due to an infection in his throat, specifically his epiglottis. Jason Phillips was escorted after he claimed he struggled to breathe. Nurses came to his cell but instead of carrying a careful medical examination, performed a penlight exam that lasted under a minute. Despite “frantic complaints of Phillips, his cellmate, and Phillips’ relatives, who were trying to secure help from the outside ()”, staff ultimately ignored their concerns until he eventually collapsed from choking. Even then they didn’t believe he was

Prison work conditions are especially harsh. The work is extremely grueling because of “almost no labor rights and [they] are paid very little, if they are paid at all. ” On top of that,

- Prison work conditions (specifically lack of precautions for individuals with special needings)
- Little boy that was raped in JM
- Wheel chair guy that couldnt get out JM

Violence and Safety

Within prisons, the security of incarcerated individuals have many threats, stemming from other inmates or staff. In the face of the criminal justice system, excessive force and inmate-on-inmate violence is highly prominent within prisons. There have been many violence-related cases that expose the correctional system’s failure to address the safety of inmates within prisons. Many prisons use a standardized system of “control” in order to keep prisoners in check. Even these universal methods pose both physical and psychological risks to the prisoners.

Within the standardized systems of prisons, recent statistics show that many inmates are often bounded or chained to shackles in various methods, which often leads to obstructed blood flow if constantly held in this type of containment (Prison Policy Initiative, 2020). There has even been a specific case where this usage of confinement reflects the excessive force brought upon the correctional system by the standardized system of prisons. A prisoner with multiple illnesses was exposed to physical trauma and pepper-spray in the act of being shackled, they ultimately died after succumbing to physical injuries alongside restricted blood flow due to his sickle cell disease (Shapiro, 2025).

Despite juveniles having a safeguard in prisons, it fails to ensure their safety. Even in the case of a juvenile, Trina Garnett, she was sexually assaulted by a prison guard, which adds to the prominent issue of having young prisoners being five times more likely to be sexually assaulted (Equal Justice Initiative, 2017). Lately, recent case studies suggest that men are most targeted by physical violence, and women are more targeted by sexual assault. This extends to both the adult and juvenile prison systems.

Table 2

Estimating the prevalence of violence in prisons and jails

Reported incidents and estimates				
Indicator of violence	State prisons	Federal prisons	County jails	Source
Deaths by suicide in correctional facility	255 deaths in 2016		333 deaths in 2016	Mortality in State and Federal Prisons, 2001-2016; Mortality in Local Jails, 2000-2016
Deaths by homicide in correctional facility	95 deaths in 2016		31 deaths in 2016	
“Intentionally injured” by staff or other incarcerated person since admission to prison	14.8% of incarcerated people in 2004	8.3% of incarcerated people in 2004	N/A	Survey of Inmates in State and Federal Correctional Facilities, 2004
“Staff-on-inmate assaults”	21% of incarcerated men were assaulted by staff over 6 months in 2005		N/A	Wolff & Shi, 2010
“Inmate-on-inmate assaults”	26,396 assaults in 2005		N/A	Census of State and Federal Adult Correctional Facilities, 2005
Incidents of sexual victimization of incarcerated people (perpetrated by staff and incarcerated people)	16,940 reported incidents in 2015	740 reported incidents in 2015	5,809 reported incidents in 2015	Survey of Sexual Victimization, 2015
1,473 substantiated incidents in state and federal prisons and local jails in 2015				

With increasingly sustained injuries and deaths every year, it suggests that the criminal justice system currently still fails to prioritize the safety of the prisoners. Even with the changing nature of allocation of its funds to different departments and uses each year, very little improvements have been made toward safety precautions for prisoners (Equal

Justice Initiative 2018). This often contributes to the growing deaths or incident reports each year for prisoners, showing how small modern prison systems have grown in terms of physical welfare when compared to past cases and their history of incidents.

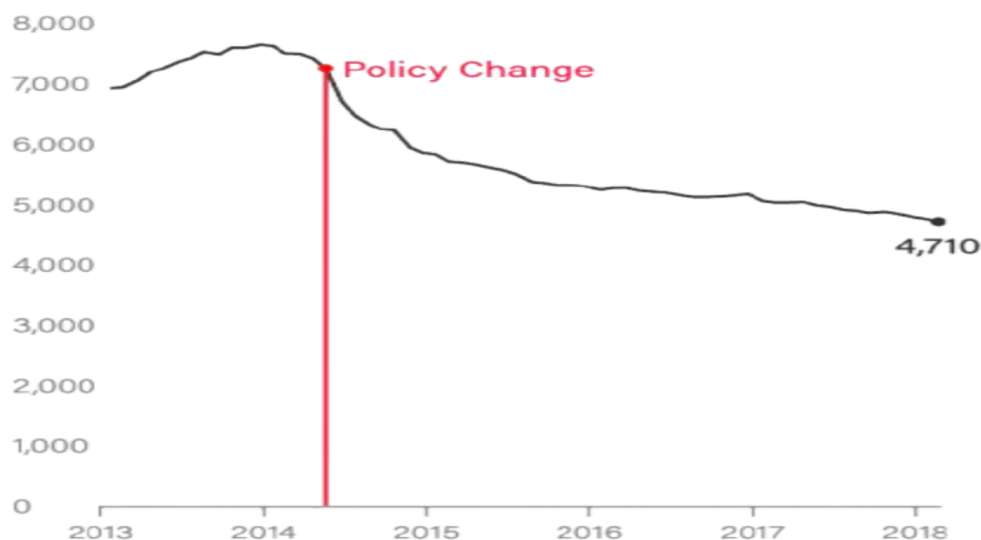
Mental Health/Suicide

The welfare of the prisoners should remain one of the top priorities of the prison system and the guards, as their well-being depends heavily on the care they receive. One such instance is seen with John Rudd. Despite making multiple suicidal claims and actions from the effect of mental health deterioration, such as self-head banging on the wall and attempting to snap his own neck, he was simply injected with an antipsychotic drug and was told that he “wasn’t ill enough to require regular treatment” (Thompson, et al. 2018). Furthermore, he was later removed from the suicide watch, and his mental health wasn’t being monitored properly. Instead of focusing on the bigger problem, the correctional system would rather resolve the situation with temporary solutions.

Another case is with Karl Taylor, who was an inmate who was first hit in the head by a prison guard. In addition, his abuse developed to the point where he couldn’t breathe in an altercation. In the aftermath, it was later revealed that he had passed away from the event. All three of the state correctional department, state police, and the local district attorney concluded that his death was caused by his declining health (Robbins, 2018). Taking in the aftermath, along with the previous case, the officials/guards are not properly monitoring the mental health of the incarcerated, all while still proceeding altercations as unprovoked violence.

In *Palakovic v. Wetzel*, Bryan Palakovic, a man in solitary confinement with “impulse control disorder, antisocial personality disorder, and alcohol dependence” attempted suicide multiple times until he ultimately succeeded (Hill, 2022). The cause for his solitary confinement was reasoned by his mental health. There, he didn’t receive proper health treatment. From his parents, they made cruel Eighth Amendment claims. The use of solitary confinement on Palakovic, who desperately needed mental health treatment, only pushed for the agenda of the officials not considering the state of the inmate, proven by cruel and unusual treatment the man received while he was suffering.

Figure 3



Source: Federal Bureau of Prisons

As seen with the graph, a policy change had played a role in the decline of mental illness treatment for federal prisoners, up to a 35% decrease (Thompson et al. 2018). These cases and events highlight the negligence and failure of the prison system to further keep in check with its inmates, and it's only continuing to get worse as the years pass unless the system and the officials decide to enforce a necessary change.

Rehabilitation

Over the past few years, there have been multiple scenarios where prison conditions were the reason behind transforming the outlook of incarcerated victims. There were even cases where innocent victims who were wrongfully convicted, were influenced after release to commit a crime due to mental pressures. In fact, recent reports over the years show high risks of mortality, elevated depression levels, worsened mood levels, and disorders being more prominent (Columbia Justice Lab, 2024). In new cases, empirical evidence suggests that even court-ordered releases that deem the convicted person “stable” still exhibit crimogenic tendencies post-release (Lofstrom, 2024). These consistent patterns highlight the critical error within the prison system’s regard to effectively rehabilitating incarcerated individuals.

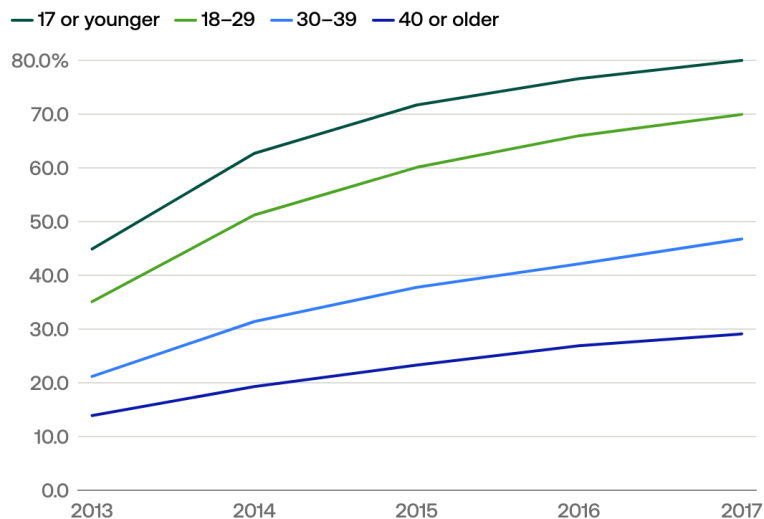
Furthermore, even when individuals are deemed as “stable” upon their release, this doesn’t necessarily mean that they are fully rehabilitated. Without consistent support and structured rehab programs both during and after incarceration, many individuals leave prison without ever confronting the underlying factors that have influenced their behavior. Within the past 10 years, roughly 79% of incarcerated U.S. individuals were more likely to be repeat offenders after previous incarceration (Alper, 2018).

Figure 4

Recidivism rates decreased with age of first arrest

Recidivism rates decreased with age of first arrest.

Percent of prisoners re-arrested within 5 years of release, by age of first arrest.



Source: Bureau of Justice Statistics

These consistent gaps in rehabilitation suggest the the likelihood of recidivism of prisoners to keep increasing throughout the years. With the individuals not being provided with effective, long-term rehabilitation programs, they often leave prison without the tools needed to successfully reintegrate into society. This often worsens their future mental health and financial situation as it becomes increasingly harder to have daily neccessities such as finding jobs, applying for insurance or loans, and having affordable housing (Nilsson et al., 2023). This ultimately contributes to a common trend of higher death rates, recidivism, or homelessness.

In hand with these ongoing issues, these drawbacks in the prison system reflect the flaws of the justice system. Rather than prioritizing long-term reform, the justice system tends to focus on emphasizing punishment and containment, which leaves little room for support or funding of a proper rehabilitation system (Nilsson et al., 2023). Even with growing awareness of these issues, many correctional facilities still lack the proper funding and resources to implement effective rehab. As a result, the justice system continues to fall short of its intended purpose, forcing it to maintain patterns for recidivism and a systematic failure to implement reintegration into society.

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Pending Sources to add to bibliography